

Content Craft

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Chapter 1 — Clarity Is Kindness

Write so a tired reader understands on the first try. Confusing writing is not sophisticated — it is a service failure. Every unnecessary word, every tangled sentence, every vague phrase taxes attention your reader was already rationing.

Short sentences are a service. They land, breathe, and move. Long sentences have their place for rhythm, but when clarity and elegance fight, clarity wins in business writing. Vary length; default short.

Prefer the concrete to the abstract. 'Revenue grew 40% after we simplified checkout' teaches; 'significant improvements were achieved through optimization efforts' obscures. Specific nouns and active verbs carry meaning; abstractions carry fog.

Cut every word doing no work. 'In order to' becomes 'to'. 'At this point in time' becomes 'now'. 'The majority of' becomes 'most'. The deletion pass alone improves most drafts by twenty percent.

Read it aloud before publishing. The ear catches what the eye forgives: tangled clauses, missing words, accidental pomposity. If you stumble reading it, readers stumble worse.

Chapter 2 — Know the Reader

Before the first word, name the one person reading. Their job, their current problem, their skepticism, their vocabulary. Writing to 'everyone' produces content for no one — specificity is not limiting, it is targeting.

Start from their question, not your knowledge. The reader arrives asking something; answer THAT first. Background can wait. Your credentials can wait. The question they carried in cannot wait even one paragraph.

Match depth to distance. Strangers need context and definitions; regulars need only the new part. Publishing the same intro for both insults one and loses the other. Know who is arriving and from where.

Use their words, not yours. Mine customer conversations, support tickets, and comments for actual phrasing. When your headline echoes the sentence already in their head, the click happens almost reflexively.

Respect their intelligence and their time equally. Do not oversimplify complex topics or overcomplicate simple ones. The craft is calibrating complexity to exactly what this reader needs to act or understand.

Chapter 3 — Structure Carries Meaning

The inverted pyramid serves every format: conclusion first, support second, background last. Readers who stop early still leave with the point. Buried ledes are buried value.

One idea per paragraph, stated in its first sentence. Paragraphs are units of thought; when a new thought begins, a new paragraph begins. Skimmers reading first sentences should get the entire argument anyway.

Headers are promises. Each section title commits to specific value; sections failing their headers betray trust built so far. Write headers as mini-headlines: useful, specific, curiosity-calibrated without clickbait rot.

Lists for parallel items, prose for reasoning. Bullets organize things (steps, options, criteria); sentences connect ideas causally. Formatting choices communicate logic structure — use them as grammar, not decoration.

End with direction, not summary. Summaries repeat; directions propel. The final lines should send readers somewhere, do something, or think something new. A piece that just stops wastes its own momentum.

Get the complete edition

The full edition of Content Craft includes all 10 chapters with end-of-chapter practice prompts.
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